

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Exercise During Pregnancy

ACOG recommends 150 minutes/week of moderate activity — safe for most pregnancies

BENEFITS OF EXERCISE

- ✓ Reduces gestational diabetes risk by up to 30%
- ✓ Lowers risk of preeclampsia and hypertension
- ✓ Reduces back pain and discomfort
- ✓ Improves mood, sleep, and energy levels
- ✓ Shorter labor and lower C-section rate
- ✓ Reduces risk of excessive weight gain
- ✓ Promotes faster postpartum recovery

ACOG RECOMMENDATIONS

- **150 min/week** of moderate aerobic activity
- Spread across most days of the week
- "Talk test" — you should be able to speak comfortably
- Warm up 5 min before, cool down 5 min after
- Stay well hydrated throughout
- Avoid exercising in heat or humidity
- After 20 weeks, avoid lying flat on back >2–3 min

SAFE ACTIVITIES SAFE

- Walking — excellent starting point for all fitness levels
- Swimming and water aerobics — low impact, joint-friendly
- Stationary cycling — no fall risk
- Prenatal yoga and Pilates — with certified instructor
- Low-impact aerobics
- Strength training with light-to-moderate weights
- Elliptical trainer

ACTIVITIES TO AVOID AVOID

- Contact sports (soccer, basketball, hockey)
- Activities with fall risk (skiing, gymnastics, horseback riding)
- Scuba diving (fetal decompression sickness risk)
- Hot yoga or hot tubs (>102°F / 39°C)
- High-altitude exercise (>6,000 feet if not acclimatized)
- Exercises requiring lying flat on back after 20 weeks
- Heavy weightlifting / Valsalva maneuver

CONTRAINDICATIONS

Exercise should be limited or avoided if you have:

- Placenta previa after 26 weeks
- Preterm labor or risk of preterm birth
- Severe anemia (Hgb <10 g/dL)
- Uncontrolled hypertension or heart disease
- Incompetent cervix or cerclage in place
- Preeclampsia or pregnancy-induced hypertension

WEIGHT GAIN GUIDELINES

- **BMI <18.5:** Gain 28–40 lbs total
- **BMI 18.5–24.9:** Gain 25–35 lbs total
- **BMI 25–29.9:** Gain 15–25 lbs total
- **BMI ≥30:** Gain 11–20 lbs total
- Exercise helps achieve healthy weight gain
- Discuss your specific goal with your provider

⚠ **STOP EXERCISING AND CALL YOUR DOCTOR IF**

- ⚠ Vaginal bleeding or fluid leaking
- ⚠ Decreased fetal movement
- ⚠ Severe shortness of breath
- ⚠ Severe headache or vision changes
- ⚠ Regular uterine contractions
- ⚠ Chest pain or palpitations
- ⚠ Dizziness or feeling faint
- ⚠ Calf pain or swelling

♥ **Moving Your Body is One of the Best Things You Can Do**

Exercise is safe for most pregnant women and offers remarkable benefits for you and your baby. Even if you weren't active before pregnancy, now is a great time to start! Begin slowly, listen to your body, and enjoy how good movement makes you feel. Every walk counts — you've got this!